

Seniors United Now

The Voice of Seniors in Alberta

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May 29, 2025

Honourable Danielle Smith - Premier

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Subject: Seniors' Health Issues

Alberta Seniors United Now (SUN) is a non-profit, non-partisan organization established in 2003 to enable all seniors in Alberta to contribute and truly participate in the well-being of the Province of Alberta.

Our members are increasingly concerned about the state of healthcare in our province. We are watching Health Care Restructuring with interest, however progress is slow and, as of yet, we see no noticeable improvement. In particular, it appears staffing has not been addressed.

In addition, following are common issues affecting seniors:

Shortage of Primary Care Providers: Many seniors experience chronic conditions that require ongoing monitoring. Without a family doctor or nurse practitioner, seniors are more likely to access Emergency Departments, contributing to already long wait times.

Seniors are seeing their long-time Family Physicians retire and are unable to find new Primary Care.

An estimated 650,000 Albertans are without a Primary Care provider. This is equal to more than half the population of the City of Edmonton.

As a seniors' advocacy organization, we do appreciate the challenges of recruiting suitable medical professionals to keep in step with population growth, however we would encourage the Alberta government to place a greater priority on recruitment.

What plans are in place to ensure appropriate staffing?

Surgery Wait Times: Many seniors struggle daily with pain and significantly reduced mobility. Wait times for a consultation have increased over the last two years. Again, that is for a consultation only. For a moment, please put yourself in the place of a senior who is experiencing significant knee or hip pain with limited mobility and must wait a year or longer for a consult. Not much of a later-in-life reward for years of hard work contributing to building this province, is it?

What assurances can you provide that wait times will be significantly reduced in the very near future?

Emergency Departments Overburdened: It is well established and obvious that seniors do not do well in Emergency Departments due to double digit wait times. Seniors need to be seen in a timely manner, or they often become confused. We have learned of an innovative geriatric multidisciplinary ER team at St. Mary's Hospital in Montreal, which works to have elderly patients discharged quickly and safely, reducing preventable harms and saving the cost of additional ER admissions.

We encourage the Alberta government to embrace a similar program.



Budget Cuts: Another significant concern for our members is the 11.5% cut to standards, licensing and monitoring for long-term care. From lessons learned during the COVID years, it is imperative that independent inspections be carried out to ensure vulnerable seniors are properly cared for. In addition, we note a 2.6% cut to palliative care programs, as well as reduced funding for continuing care beds, which seems contrary to Best Practices for an aging population.

How will your government ensure that long term care facilities follow the rules?

Paying Out of Pocket: Contrary to popular belief, all seniors are not rich, with many struggling financially. Seniors Basic Blue Cross is just that – basic. Typically, a senior that wants or needs more coverage may be forced to pay over \$200 per month. A senior reports he requires HPAC equipment, glasses and hearing aides. He does not have the financial resources to pay for all of these and must make difficult decisions. Furthermore, transportation cost is an issue for many who must attend appointments far from home.

How will your government address issues of financial strain so that seniors may enjoy the quality of life we all hope for?

We do get the occasional report from a SUN member who has had a positive experience with healthcare and for those, we are deeply appreciative.

It is the goal of Seniors United Now to have a meaningful working relationship with Alberta Health Services and the Province that would ultimately improve quality of life and outcomes for Alberta seniors. To that end, we ask the Province to consider a joint working group that would collaborate in establishing achievable goals related to improving seniors' healthcare.

Sincerely,

Wayne Sorenson

President

cc:

The Honourable Adriana LaGrange - Minister of Primary and Preventative Health Services

Honourable Matt Jones - Minister of Hospital and Surgical Health Services

Honourable Jason Nixon - Minister of Assisted Living and Social Services

Honourable Sarah Hoffman - NDP Health Critic

Chris Gallaway, Executive Director- Friends of Medicare

Brad LaFortune, Executive Director – Public Interest Alberta